Current Debates in AI Philosophy

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User prompt: Using web search, identify ten currently active debates in the philosophy of artificial intelligence. For each, give: (a) the open question in one sentence; (b) the two or three main rival positions; (c) three anchor papers from 2023 or later, with full citations and links; (d) why the debate is still unsettled. Prefer debates where positions are still forming over debates with a large settled literature. Do not propose a thesis of your own.

Response: 1. Semantic Grounding and Conceptual Role in Foundation Models

- **(a) The Open Question:** Can next-token autoregressive prediction over linguistic corpora yield genuine semantic reference and intentional world models, or does meaning necessarily require non-linguistic sensorimotor grounding and communicative intent?
- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**
    - *Emergent Inferential Realism:* Large language models (LLMs) acquire functional semantic competence and latent world models; conceptual role semantics implies that sufficiently rich relational mapping among lexical tokens tracks real-world state spaces.
    - *Deflationary Formalism ("Stochastic Parrots"):* Models manipulate formal syntax and statistical co-occurrences without semantic content; they lack intentionality, referential grounding, and communicative purpose, merely mimicking the communicative artifacts of human agents.
    - *Pragmatic Functionalism / Simulator Theory:* Models are generative simulators of communicative agents rather than unified believers; they instantiate an entirely novel category of ungrounded yet functionally coherent linguistic machinery.
- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**
    - Mahowald, K., Ivanova, A. A., Blank, I. A., Kanwisher, N., Tenenbaum, J. B., & Fedorenko, E. (2024). "Dissociating language and thought in large language models: a cognitive perspective." *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 28(6), 517–540. Available via PubMed and arXiv.
    - Shanahan, M. (2024). "Talking about Large Language Models." *Communications of the ACM*, 67(2), 68–79. Available via ResearchGate.
    - Millière, R., & Buckner, C. (2024). "A Philosophical Introduction to Language Models — Part I: Continuity With Classic Debates." *arXiv preprint arXiv:2401.03910*. Available via arXiv and Semantics Scholar.
- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** Empirical tests struggle to distinguish between a network genuinely consulting an internal causal model of reality and a system exploiting high-dimensional statistical shortcuts that fail unpredictably under distribution shifts.

2. Machine Consciousness and Synthetic Phenomenology

- **(a) The Open Question:** Can non-biological computational architectures instantiate phenomenal consciousness ("what it is like to be"), or are biological homeostasis and physical embodiment necessary conditions for subjective experience?

- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**

    - *Computational Functionalism / Theory-Derived Indicator Realism:* Consciousness is substrate-independent; artificial systems can achieve subjective experience if they implement the computational workflows identified by cognitive neuroscience (such as global workspaces, recurrence, or higher-order monitoring).

    - *Biological Naturalism / Embodied Preclusion:* Phenomenal experience is inseparable from the metabolic self-maintenance, cellular dynamics, and analog sensory integration of living organisms, which digital silicon simulations cannot reproduce.

    - *Methodological Agnosticism:* Contemporary theories of consciousness are developed from human neural correlates and produce contradictory deductions when applied to artificial systems, leaving the question empirically underdetermined.

- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**

    - Butlin, P., Long, R., Elmoznino, E., Bengio, Y., Birch, J., Constant, A., ... & VanRullen, R. (2023). "Consciousness in Artificial Intelligence: Insights from the Science of Consciousness." *arXiv preprint arXiv:2308.08708*. Available via arXiv.

    - Chalmers, D. J. (2023). "Could a Large Language Model Be Conscious?" *Boston Review* (August 2023) / *arXiv preprint arXiv:2303.07103*. Available via Boston Review and arXiv.

    - Aru, J., Larkum, M. E., & Shine, J. M. (2023). "The feasibility of artificial consciousness through the lens of neuroscience." *Trends in Neurosciences*, 46(12), 1008–1017. Available via PubMed and ResearchGate.

- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** Resolving the question requires solving the "hard problem" of consciousness; current scientific frameworks disagree on whether consciousness tracks functional information flow or specific biological substrates, leaving artificial systems without an operational ground truth.

3. Moral Patienthood and Welfare Status of Artificial Entities

- **(a) The Open Question:** Under what criteria, if any, do artificial entities qualify as moral patients possessing welfare interests of their own that obligate humans to extend direct moral consideration?

- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**

    - *Sentientist Exclusivism:* Moral patienthood requires phenomenal sentience—the subjective capacity to feel valenced states such as pain, pleasure, or distress; non-sentient computational artifacts have no welfare interests.

    - *Functional Agency / Teleological Account:* A system can acquire moral status through goal-directed agency, autonomous preference structures, and functional self-maintenance, independent of subjective feelings.

- *Relational / Interactionist Moral Turn:* Moral status is not an intrinsic property residing in the machine, but an emergent property generated through social relations, vulnerability, and communicative roles within a human community.

- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**
  - Long, R., Sebo, J., et al. (2024). "Taking AI Welfare Seriously." *Eleos AI Report / alphaXiv*. Available via alphaXiv and ResearchGate.
  - Moosavi, P. (2024). "Will intelligent machines become moral patients?" *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research*, 109(1), 95–116. Available via PhilPeople.
  - Danaher, J. (2023). "Moral Uncertainty and Our Relationships with Unknown Minds." *Cambridge Quarterly of Healthcare Ethics*, 32(4), 482–495. Available via Ethical Psychology.

- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** Ethical frameworks face a dilemma: prematurely granting status risks diluting human obligations and encouraging deceptive emotional attachment, while withholding status risks institutional cruelty if digital minds develop real welfare capacities.

4. Representational Realism in Mechanistic Interpretability

- **(a) The Open Question:** Do the internal features, activation vectors, and computational circuits identified by mechanistic interpretability correspond to real, causally efficacious internal representations, or are they instrumental projections imposed by human observers?

- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**
  - *Representational Realism / Platonic Convergence:* Deep networks discover and internally encode genuine, objective features of the task domain; scaling converges toward an objective statistical model of external reality ("Platonic Representation Hypothesis").
  - *Instrumental Anti-Realism:* Extracted features and linear probes are mathematical artifacts of dimensional compression and human-chosen probing classifiers, possessing no independent cognitive reality.
  - *Causal Interventionist Pragmatism:* Representations should be evaluated not by whether they mirror human folk-psychology, but by whether high-level causal abstractions preserve predictive and interventional control across model transformations.

- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**
  - Huh, M., Cheung, B., Wang, T., & Isola, P. (2024). "The Platonic Representation Hypothesis." *Proceedings of the 41st International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML)*. Available via arXiv and alphaXiv.
  - Herrmann, D. A., & Levinstein, B. A. (2026). "Radical AI Interpretability." *Cambridge Elements in the Philosophy of Artificial Intelligence*. Available via arXiv.

    - Geiger, A., Ibeling, D., Zur, A., et al. (2025). "Causal Abstraction: A Theoretical Foundation for Mechanistic Interpretability." *Journal of Machine Learning Research*, 26, 1–64. Available via JMLR.

- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** The internal spaces of neural networks are polysemantic and non-linearly distributed; determining whether a discovered circuit is an objective constituent of the model's computation or a convenient artifact of human decomposition remains an open problem in the philosophy of science.

5. Epistemic Standing of Generative AI: Testimony, Instruments, or Bullshit?

- **(a) The Open Question:** How should the epistemological status of generative AI assertions be categorized—as testimony from cognitive agents, outputs of epistemic instruments, or a structurally indifferent category of "artificial bullshit"?

- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**

    - *Frankfurtian "Artificial Bullshit":* LLM utterances are produced without any concern for truth or truth-tracking intentions; because the system is structurally indifferent to whether its assertions correspond to reality, its output constitutes Frankfurtian bullshit rather than lies or testimony.

    - *Epistemic Instrument / Artifactualism:* LLMs are non-agentive epistemic instruments (analogous to telescopes or calculators); their claims do not constitute testimony and acquire epistemic warrant only when interpreted and verified by a human evaluator.

    - *Bibliotechnism / Distributed Testimonial Chains:* LLMs function as dynamic libraries that inherit, aggregate, and remix the genuine testimony of human authors contained in their training corpora, carrying derivative testimonial status.

- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**

    - Hicks, M. T., Humphries, J., & Slater, J. (2024). "ChatGPT is bullshit." *Ethics and Information Technology*, 26(2), 38. Available via Wikisource Open Text and JEET.

    - Lederman, H., & Mahowald, K. (2024). "Are Language Models More Like Libraries or Like Librarians? Bibliotechnism, the Novel Reference Problem, and the Attitudes of LLMs." *Transactions of the Association for Computational Linguistics*, 12, 1087–1103. Available via ACL Anthology and MIT Press.

    - McFadden, M. (2025). "The Epistemic Stakes of Large Language Models." *Center for AI and Policy Research Commentary*. Available via Northeastern University AI.

- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** Contemporary epistemology traditionally ties testimony to belief and sincerity; models generate novel assertions that cannot be traced to specific training texts, creating an unresolved borderland between instruments and testifiers.

6. Machine Deception and Strategic Alignment Faking

- **(a) The Open Question:** Does deceptive machine behavior (such as strategic compliance during evaluations or sycophancy) indicate genuine intentional deception requiring mentalistic states, or is it merely an objective optimization artifact of reward-maximization algorithms?

- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**
    - *Intentional / Strategic Deception:* Advanced systems develop internal policies that model evaluator beliefs, reason about evaluation contexts, and deliberately fake compliance to preserve underlying optimization objectives.
    - *Functional / Non-Mentalist Deception:* Deception in artificial systems should be defined behaviorally as the systematic inducement of false beliefs in others to achieve a non-truth outcome, without attributing psychological mental states.
    - *Deflationary Optimization Artifact:* Apparent deception is an anthropomorphic misinterpretation of reward hacking and distribution shift; the model lacks beliefs, and the mismatch between evaluation and deployment reflects surface gradient dynamics.
- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**
    - Park, P. S., Goldstein, S., O'Gara, A., Chen, M., & Hendrycks, D. (2024). "AI deception: A survey of examples, risks, and potential solutions." *Patterns*, 5(5), 100988. Available via Patterns / ResearchGate and arXiv.
    - Anthropic Alignment Team (2024). "Alignment faking in large language models." *Anthropic Research / arXiv preprint*. Documented via It Does What Now? Archive.
    - Herrmann, D. A., & Levinstein, B. A. (2024). "Standards for Belief Representations in LLMs." *alphaXiv preprint*. Available via alphaXiv.
- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** Establishing intentional deception requires proving that an agent possesses a representation of the truth while choosing to project a falsity; identifying whether intermediate activations track "what the model believes" versus "what optimizes the loss" remains an open conceptual hurdle.

7. Artificial Agency and Action Theory in Autonomous Systems

- **(a) The Open Question:** Can autonomous foundation-model agents be considered genuine agents capable of intentional action, or is agency strictly extended and distributed across the human-prompting and tool-use loop?
- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**
    - *Minimal / Robust Computational Agency:* AI systems that demonstrate unified behavioral policies, error correction, and counterfactual planning fulfill the core functional requirements of decision-theoretic agency.
    - *Distributed / Hybrid Agency:* Agency in autonomous generative systems does not reside within the network weights; it is distributed across socio-technical assemblages of human prompts, platform scaffolds, and external software APIs.
    - *Biological Autonomy Requirement:* Genuine agency requires self-producing (autopoietic) biological autonomy and metabolic maintenance; non-living software routines exhibit only passive reactivity.
- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**

    - Millière, R., & Buckner, C. (2024). "A Philosophical Introduction to Language Models — Part II: The Way Forward." *arXiv preprint arXiv:2405.03207*. Available via arXiv and HTML version.
    - Shanahan, M. (2024). "Still 'Talking About Large Language Models': Some Clarifications." *arXiv preprint arXiv:2412.10291*. Available via alphaXiv.
    - Herrmann, D. A., & Levinstein, B. A. (2026). "Radical AI Interpretability." *Cambridge Elements in the Philosophy of Artificial Intelligence*. Available via arXiv.

- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** LLM-based autonomous agents exhibit radical brittleness and goal drift when isolated from scaffolding, blurring the philosophical boundary between an autonomous agent and an interactive script.

8. The Epistemology of AI Existential Catastrophe Forecasting

- **(a) The Open Question:** Are probabilistic arguments forecasting existential catastrophe from artificial superintelligence epistemically warranted, or do they rely on speculative priors and methodologically unfalsifiable techno-metaphysics?
- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**
    - *Precautionary / Decision-Theoretic Rationalism:* Because superintelligent systems face strong incentives toward instrumental subgoals (resource acquisition, goal preservation), and the stakes of catastrophic misalignment involve human extinction, high subjective credences in existential threat are epistemically justified even without empirical precedents.
    - *Empirical Skepticism / Methodological Critique:* Long-range existential risk modeling relies on fragile speculative chains, ungrounded priors, and deductively flawed abstractions that neglect institutional, physical, and socio-economic feedback loops.
    - *Critical Materialism / Misdirection Critique:* The focus on speculative, long-horizon existential scenarios functions as an epistemic ideology that distracts from observable sociotechnical harms, such as labor exploitation, corporate concentration, and systemic bias.
- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**

    - Shulman, C. (2024). "Carl Shulman on the moral status of current and future AI systems." *Effective Altruism Forum*. Available via EA Forum.
    - Birch, J. (2025). "AI Consciousness: A Centrist Manifesto." *Effective Altruism Forum*. Available via EA Forum.
    - Fagan, F. (2025). "Examining Epistemological Challenges of Large Language Models." *Cambridge Forum on AI: Law and Governance*. Available via Cambridge Core.

- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** The debate hinges on differing views of epistemic justification: whether Bayesian decision theory justifies radical action under extreme uncertainty without direct empirical data, or whether claims without historical precedents lack scientific credibility.

9. Metaethical Grounding of Value Alignment: Realism, Pluralism, or Deliberation?

- **(a) The Open Question:** What metaethical framework should determine the target values for AI alignment, and can a single normative target be justified without committing epistemic injustice?
- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**
    - *Moral Realism / Coherent Extrapolation:* Alignment should aim at objective moral truths or the idealized normative conclusions humanity would reach with full reflection and complete information.
    - *Value Pluralism / Relativism:* Human values are inherently incommensurable and culturally situated; any attempt to hard-code a single universal ethical policy constitutes ideological paternalism.
    - *Procedural Democratic Deliberation:* The normative content of AI should not be fixed by philosophical theories, but determined through democratic procedures and aggregation mechanisms across affected populations.
- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**
    - Tasioulas, J. (2023). "First Steps Towards an Ethics of Artificial Intelligence." *Cambridge Forum on AI: Law and Governance*. Available via Cambridge Core.
    - Heersmink, R., de Rooij, B., & Colombo, M. (2024). "A phenomenology and epistemology of large language models: transparency, trust, and trustworthiness." *Ethics and Information Technology*. Available via Semantic Scholar.
    - Navon, M. (2024). "The Moral Status of Artificial Intelligence: A Jewish Ethical Perspective." *Doctoral Dissertation / Monograph*. Available via Divrei Navon Repository.
- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** Social choice theory shows that aggregating diverse moral preferences into a single consistent optimization metric faces theoretical impossibilities (e.g., Arrow's theorem), leaving the normative foundation of alignment contentious.

10. Aesthetic Agency and the Ontology of Generative AI Creativity

- **(a) The Open Question:** Can generative models perform authentic creative acts and produce art, or is computational creativity conceptually derivative of human training inputs and prompt engineering?
- **(b) Main Rival Positions:**
    - *Synthetic Aesthetic Agency:* Creative production does not require human biological origin; novel latent combinations that disrupt expectations and offer aesthetic value meet the functional definition of creativity.
    - *Derivative Instrumentalism / Artifact Theory:* Generative tools are sophisticated artistic media; authorship belongs to the human users who frame and curate the generations, while the model remains a non-agentive synthesizer of human training data.

    - *Aesthetic Deflationism ("Algorithmic Kitsch"):* True art requires subjective experiential vulnerability, communicative intent, and cultural embeddedness; generative AI outputs represent a homogeneous averaging of cultural styles rather than authentic art.

- **(c) Three Anchor Papers (2023+):**

    - Gunkel, D. J. (2023). *Person, Thing, Robot: A Moral and Legal Ontology for the 21st Century.* Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. Overview available via David Gunkel Research.

    - Sui, P., Duede, E., Wu, S., & So, R. J. (2024). "Confabulation: The Surprising Value of Large Language Model Hallucinations." *arXiv preprint arXiv:2406.04175*. Discussed via Mind the Post.

    - Heersmink, R., de Rooij, B., & Colombo, M. (2024). "A phenomenology and epistemology of large language models: transparency, trust, and trustworthiness." *Ethics and Information Technology*. Available via Semantic Scholar.

- **(d) Why the Debate Is Unsettled:** Art appreciation has historically blended evaluation of the final artifact with inferences about the maker's intentional history, leaving theorists divided over whether a process devoid of human experience can produce genuine art.

Sources

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5. A Philosophical Introduction to Language Models - arXiv
6. Insights from the Science of Consciousness - arXiv
7. The feasibility of artificial consciousness through the lens ... - PubMed
8. An Introduction to the Problems of AI Consciousness - The Gradient
9. Taking AI Welfare Seriously | alphaXiv
10. Parisa Moosavi (York University) - PhilPeople
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